

The history of coffee cultivation and trade dates back centuries, with the earliest credible evidence of the plant appearing in the Sufi shrines of Yemen in the 15th century. Coffee began to spread from the Arabian Peninsula into Egypt, Persia, and Turkey, and from there into the Balkans, Italy, and the rest of Europe by the 17th century. Coffeeshouses quickly became important social hubs, often described as centers of intellectual exchange where people gathered to discuss politics, business, and art over a shared cup.

As European colonial powers expanded their reach, coffee cultivation spread to their colonies in the Americas, Africa, and Asia. The Dutch introduced coffee cultivation to Indonesia in the late 17th century, while the French and Portuguese brought the plant to the Caribbean and South America shortly after. Brazil, in particular, would go on to become the largest coffee producer in the world by the 19th century, a position it still holds today, supplying a substantial portion of the global coffee supply.

Modern coffee production involves a complex international supply chain, from small-scale farmers growing beans on hillside plantations to large processing facilities that roast, grind, and package coffee for shipment worldwide. The industry supports the livelihoods of millions of people, particularly in developing countries where coffee is often one of the primary agricultural exports. However, the industry also faces significant challenges, including price volatility, climate change impacts on growing regions, and ongoing questions about fair compensation for farmers at the bottom of the supply chain.

In recent decades, the rise of specialty coffee and direct trade relationships has attempted to address some of these concerns by paying farmers a premium for higher-quality beans and more transparent sourcing practices. Consumer interest in the origin and ethical sourcing of coffee has grown substantially, leading to the widespread adoption of certifications such as Fair Trade and Rainforest Alliance, though debates continue about how effectively these programs improve conditions for the farmers they are meant to support.